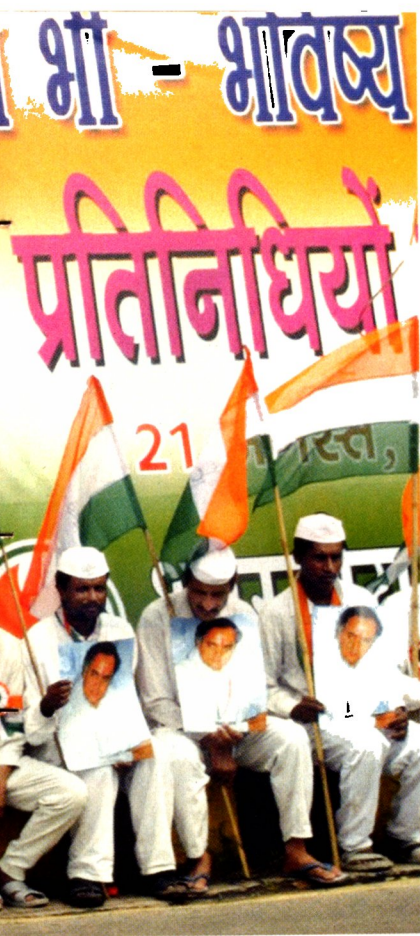




AP PHOTO

is none other than the heir apparent. Tanwar cites the example of a Congressman's son who was working against the party. The rcc chief called and said, "We cannot take action against the father as he is a senior leader, but what are you doing about the son?" Tanwar adds with a self-satisfied smile, "We had already expelled the son. Earlier, even if we had expelled him, a phone call would have come to reverse this. Now no such calls come."

Meanwhile, no one bothers to call the Seva Dal, neither the young scion, nor any senior leader. The organisation was set up in 1923 to help the families of the jailed freedom fighters. Later it merged with the Congress. "Our role is to prepare a team of workers for the main party," says Joshi, the chief organiser. A well-meaning man, the 50-year-old Joshi lacks the stature of a Gandhi to achieve much. The last time Sonia Gandhi, chairperson of the Seva Dal, attended a training camp was

Feeder Channels

THE SEVA DAL

Was set up in 1923 to help the families of jailed freedom fighters. Headed by 50-year-old Mahendra Joshi, it has only a ceremonial role in the party.

INDIAN YOUTH CONGRESS

Established in 1969, it peaked during Sanjay Gandhi's era. Headed by 33-year-old Ashok Tanwar, it has taken off again under Rahul's patronage.

THE NATIONAL STUDENTS UNION OF INDIA

Set up in 1971. The current chief, 26-year-old Hibe Eden, was chosen by Rahul after several rounds of interviews.

THE MAHILA CONGRESS

Headed by Sonia-loyalist Prabha Thakur, it takes up routine women-related issues.

THE INDIAN NATIONAL TRADE UNION OF INDIA

Founded in 1947 on Gandhian ideals, it is more visible in seminars than for union work. Current chief is Sanjeeva Reddy.

more than five years ago in Jaipur when she spent three days closely monitoring a routine that began with physical training (PT) at 4 a.m., followed by flag-hoisting drills and later classes where they were taught Vande Mataram and the National Anthem. A far cry from the time when Rajiv Gandhi made it mandatory for all Congress leaders under 50 to do PT at the Seva Dal camps.

Today, in the Council of Ministers, only a handful like Mukul Wasnik, Harish Rawat, Virbhadr Singh have been associated with the Seva Dal. The organisation is now reduced to ceremonial pawns on display at party functions. Jawaharlal Nehru had envisaged the organisation as a counter to the more high profile RSS. Its workers are supposed to help out in disaster zones but somehow it is the RSS and not the Seva Dal that steals the thunder. "The RSS is only active during photo-shoots. Their khaki knickers makes them easy to spot," says Joshi defensively.

The Seva Dal workers are identified with their distinctive Gandhi topis. But these are worn only on special occasions. Former Seva Dal chief Prahlad Yadav used to complain that the minute the workers wore them, they were sent off on an errand by a senior leader. More than a wardrobe glitch, the Seva Dal is going through an identity crisis.

MANEESH AGNIHOTRI



ARGE, THE YOUTH CONGRESS WAS A BUNCH OF BRASH, AIMLESS, NOT-SO-YOUNG MEN.